



BIOGRAPHY

JOSEPHINE BAKER

Born in 1906 in the US, Baker began her career as a street performer, but quickly landed a role in *Shuffle Along* on Broadway. Her talent led her to tour Paris in 1925, where she opened *La Revue Nègre* at the Theatre des Champs-Élysées. She rose to fame with her *Danse Sauvage*, performed wearing a girdle of bananas and accompanied by her pet cheetah. Baker was married four times but also had relationships with women. She later aided the French resistance during World War II and supported the US Civil Rights movement.

that borrowed from men's fashions and emphasized women's comfort.

In the United States, women fought on both sides of the Prohibition debate—from 1920, the consumption of alcohol was forbidden by the 18th Amendment. While the Women's Christian Temperance Union supported the law, flappers often flaunted it, enjoying the illicit atmosphere of speakeasies (underground clubs that sold liquor). Flappers had equivalents around the world—from the German *neue Frauen* to the Japanese *moga* and Chinese *modeng xiaojie*—who wore the new fashions, shocked others with their promiscuity, and challenged their society's conventions.

In Paris, the 1920s were known as the *années folles*, or “the crazy years.” Café society created spaces where artists and writers of any gender could gather to socialize. This spirit was echoed in British dance halls and American speakeasies, where jazz's improvisational nature encouraged a spirit of release. In Germany, the decade was called the “Golden Twenties” thanks to the nation's economic growth and liberal creative *zeitgeist*. Berlin was enthralled by stars such as Anita Berber, a bisexual dancer and actress renowned for her brazen nude performances. However, the 1920s were not a time of liberation for all women. In the US, for example, heightened racial tension saw the



◀ Flapper handbag

Flapper bags were only able to fit some money and cigarettes—all a woman needed for an unchaperoned night on the town. Bags were often intricately decorated—in this case, in 1920s art deco style—with tassels that swayed as a woman danced.

rebirth of the Ku Klux Klan, a white supremacist organization, race riots, and the institution of restrictive immigration quotas.

From boom to bust

Beneath the surface, economies had been struggling. Participating nations were still paying for World War I, and adapting to the new economic state proved difficult. This struggle culminated in 1929 when the Wall Street stock market crashed, setting the Great Depression in motion. Unemployment levels soared, and working class men were hit hard as many manufacturing industries shut down. In contrast, women's jobs in traditional service industries remained relatively safe; many working-class women became their families' sole breadwinners. Working women were not protected by employment laws; some married women with working husbands did not qualify for jobs, and those who had them could be fired instantly if they became pregnant. While the 1920s were a time of liberation, the decade that followed had an entirely different character.

▶ Flappers of the Prohibition Era

Contempt for the rules of Prohibition heavily influenced American flappers. Some chose to be photographed drinking liquor or defiantly smuggling flasks in their stockings, clothes, and purses.



**“THE NEW WOMAN ...
ASSERTED HER RIGHT
TO DANCE, DRINK,
SMOKE, AND DATE.”**

JOSHUA ZEITZ, US HISTORIAN, IN HIS BOOK *FLAPPER*, 2006